

"One is not born,
but rather
becomes,
a woman."

SIMONE DE BEAUVOIR, WRITER AND POLITICAL ACTIVIST,
THE SECOND SEX, 1949

FEMININITY AND SOCIETY

In her book *The Second Sex*, French feminist Simone de Beauvoir broke new ground: she separated the concept of gender from biological sex. De Beauvoir believed that gender roles are socially constructed, and that rather than having some biological basis, femininity is something that girls learn through socialization. From a young age, girls are conditioned to accept dependence and passivity as integral parts of what it means to be feminine. For example, girls are taught that they should strive to be pretty and conform to feminine ideals in order to appeal to men; by doing so, they become passive objects for men to look at. One of society's most glaring objectifications of women (and girls) is the beauty pageant. In this photograph, taken at the Miss Pears pageant in London in 1973, girls compete to be crowned the most beautiful.

